PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY MARK SCHEME

Best Guess Mock Exam 4: School Desegregation and Little Rock (1957)

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75 (1HI0/33)

Question 1: Inference from Source A (4 Marks)

Target: AO3 (4 marks). Award 1 mark for each valid inference, up to 2. Award 1 mark for each corresponding quote/detail, up to 2.

Sample Acceptable Inferences (the crowd outside Central High School, Little Rock, in September 1957):

• **Inference 1:** The white mob outside the school was openly hostile and abusive toward the incoming Black students.

- *Detail from source:* "The crowd outside the school is extremely loud and aggressive. When the nine Negro students arrived, white adults began shouting abuse and spitting in their direction."

• **Inference 2:** State troops deployed by the Governor actively blocked desegregation rather than controlling the crowd.

- *Detail from source:* "The Arkansas National Guard... stood in a line blockading the entrance. They did not attempt to disperse the mob; instead, their presence clearly prevented the children from entering..."

Question 2: Causal Explanation (12 Marks)

Target: AO1/AO2 (12 marks). Level 4 (10–12 marks): An analytical explanation showing a line of reasoning with clear links to the outcome, supported by accurate, detailed knowledge.

“One reason why school desegregation met with significant opposition in the years 1954–57 was the widespread anger and resistance triggered by the Brown v. Board of Education ruling.” In 1954, the Supreme Court declared segregated schools unconstitutional, challenging the Southern way of life. Southern politicians and citizens viewed this as an illegal federal intrusion into state rights. *Therefore, the Brown ruling was a primary cause of opposition because it threatened the social structure of the South, provoking a coordinated segregationist backlash to defend local racial customs.*

“A second reason why school desegregation met with significant opposition was the rapid growth and organization of White Citizens' Councils.” Founded in 1954, these councils consisted of middle-class white professionals who used economic pressure to target supporters of integration, firing Black workers and evicting tenants who signed desegregation petitions. *Therefore, the White Citizens' Councils were a key cause of opposition because they successfully intimidated the local Black community, making it dangerous for parents to enroll their children in integrated schools.*

“A third reason why school desegregation met with significant opposition was the political strategy of 'Massive Resistance' promoted by Southern state leaders.” Southern governors and senators signed the Southern Manifesto, pledging to block integration by any lawful means, and passed state laws that closed public schools down rather than allowing integration. *Therefore, this political obstruction was a decisive cause of opposition because it gave official, legal backing to segregationist resistance, leading directly to crises like the military blockade in Little Rock.*

Question 3(a): Source Utility (8 Marks)

Target: AO3 (8 marks). Assess content utility, verify with contextual knowledge, and evaluate provenance reliability and limitations for BOTH sources.

Source B is highly useful for demonstrating the intense, terrifying hostility and physical danger faced by the Black students during the Little Rock crisis. Eckford describes how state guards raised bayonets to block her entry, and how she was followed by a screaming mob shouting "Lynch her!", capturing the immediate trauma of the event. This utility is supported by my knowledge that the Little Rock Nine faced severe abuse on their first day of school, requiring them to be protected by federal troops eventually, which verifies the extreme danger described by Eckford. The provenance of a first-hand recollection by one of the nine students makes the source extremely useful for understanding the psychological toll of massive resistance on the children. However, as a retrospective account, it represents a highly emotional, personal viewpoint that focuses on individual experience rather than the broader political decisions of the state and federal governments.

Source C is highly useful for showing the official federal response and the president's justification for using military force to enforce integration. President Eisenhower declares that "mob rule... cannot be allowed to override the decisions of our courts" and announces that he has sent the 101st Airborne Division to Central High School to protect the students. This content's usefulness is verified by my knowledge that Eisenhower's intervention was a historic first since Reconstruction, sending 1,000 federal paratroopers to enforce a Supreme Court desegregation order against a defiant governor, confirming the federal commitment to maintain the rule of law. The provenance of a national radio address to the American people on 24 September 1957 makes the source very useful for showing how the president framed the crisis as a matter of constitutional authority and national prestige rather than a moral crusade for civil rights, though it is limited as a public address designed to restore calm and defuse international embarrassment.

Question 3(b): Difference Between Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Identify the main difference of view, supported by details from both interpretations.

The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that the Little Rock crisis was a **"huge victory for the civil rights movement"** because it showed the federal government was willing to use military force. In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that it showed the **"severe limitations of federal intervention"** because it provoked a backlash that slowed down integration.

Question 3(c): Reason for Difference in Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Explain how the historians may have relied on different sources to reach their views.

The interpretations differ because the historians have focused on different outcomes. Interpretation 1 is supported by Source C, which details how President Eisenhower deployed the "101st Airborne Division" to enforce the law, leading to the view that it was a **"huge victory"** that proved federal commitment. Conversely, Interpretation 2 is supported by Source B, which show that the students faced extreme danger and were blocked by the "guards", leading to the view that it showed the **"severe limitations of federal intervention"** on the ground.

Question 3(d): Evaluation of Interpretation (16 Marks + 4 SPaG)

Target: AO4 (16 marks) + SPaG (4 marks). Level 4 (13–16 marks): Balanced discussion analyzing both interpretations with sustained contextual knowledge, leading to a justified judgment.

I agree to a moderate extent with Interpretation 1 that Little Rock was a significant victory. As shown in Source C, President Eisenhower took the unprecedented step of sending the **101st Airborne Division** and federalising the national guard to protect the students. This proved to Southern governors that they could not openly defy federal court rulings, and the images of federal soldiers protecting Black children won immense national and international support. This matches Interpretation 1's view that the crisis was a **"huge victory"** that **"showed that the federal government was willing to use military force"**.

However, Interpretation 2 is also valid in identifying the severe limits of this success. As Elizabeth Eckford recalls in Source B, the initial experience was a **terrifying** ordeal where she was blocked by **guards** and faced **hostile** crowds, showing the depth of local resistance. In fact, the following year in **1958**, Governor Faubus closed all four of Little Rock's public high schools for the entire academic year (the 'Lost Year') to prevent further integration. This confirms Interpretation 2's argument that the crisis **"showed the severe limitations of federal intervention"** and **"actually slowed down the pace of integration"** as Southern resistance hardened.

Overall, while the immediate local outcome in Little Rock was limited and met with political sabotage (Interpretation 2), the national precedent was a major victory. It established that the executive branch would use military force to enforce civil rights, which was a vital step forward that paved the way for subsequent federal legislation.